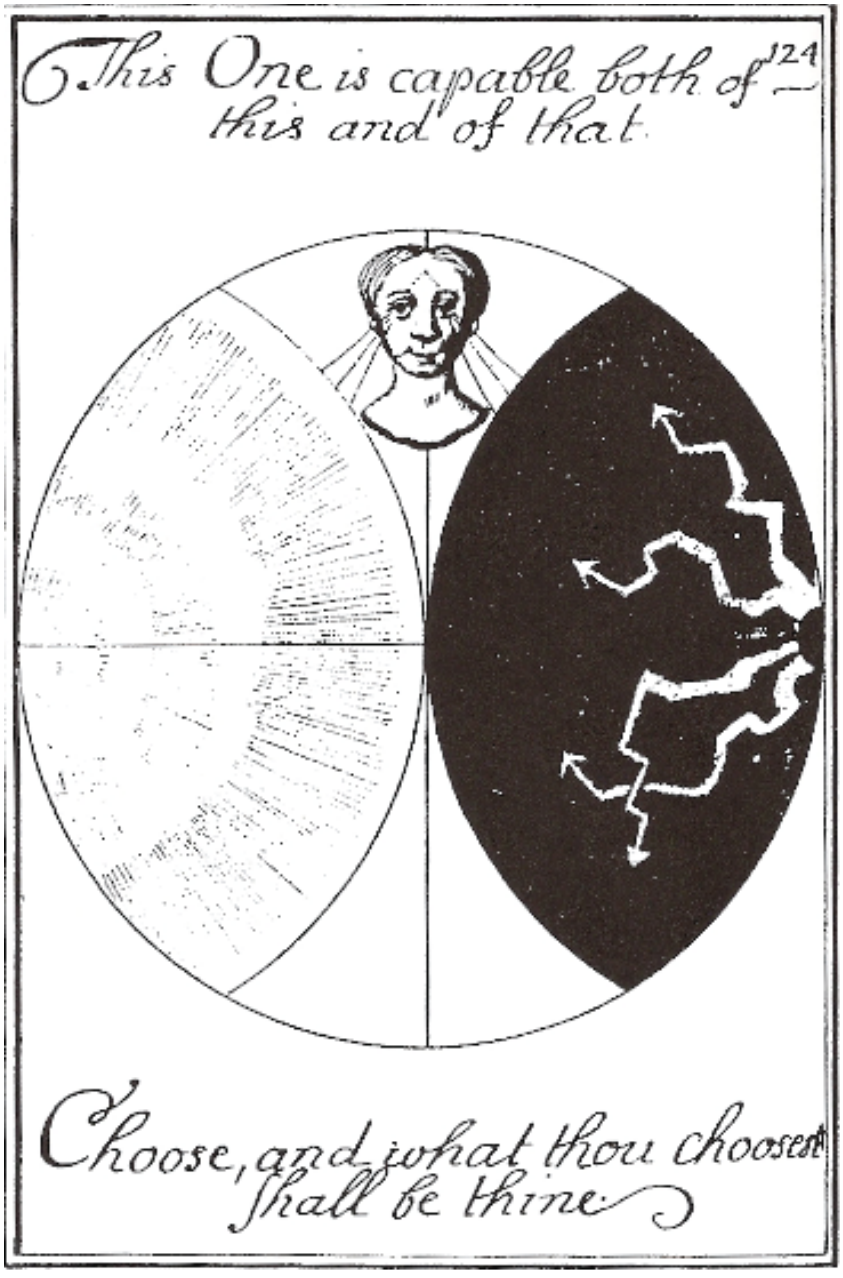
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Hollerbeier Haven

Journal of Traditional Deitsch Wisdom

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Die Volkstimme





The Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts is recording stories, interviews, memories, and knowledge of the healing traditions of Pow-wow or Braucherei. We are creating an archive of this tradition in order to preserve our heritage and ensure the practice. If you know anyone who practices or has a story to tell, we'd love to hear from you; whether you'd like to give a personal interview or prefer to remain anonymous, simply write to us. Your personal experiences are culturally valuable and will be treated with the utmost respect. You can contact us with questions or information by writing to:

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Hello to all of our readers!

The summer is here and as you can see there have been some changes at the Three Sisters Center. This is the first issue of our newsletter for which Jesse has been the Editor, and as you can see she has given it her own touch. Jesse and Matthew have been very busy with their son Elijah and with the construction of their home

Susan has been very busy, teaching two full classes of Homestead Herbalism, not to mention her many other events at the Farm at Coventry. She will still be keeping her hands and heart in the happenings at Three Sisters, however, sending in some herbal articles and making appearances at our guild meetings!

Rob has been teaching Deitsch since last August, at KU and is loving it! He is now in the process of forming community classes that are more affordable and available to all. He is also involved in the creation of a Deitsch curriculum for pre-school and elementary school students for a forming alternative school in the area.

Patrick has just finished his Bachelor's Degree at Kutztown University and will be spending much of the next year helping Matthew and Jesse to build their house. He continues his study of barn art and Deitsch symbology.

Lauren is currently focused on the creation of a bioregional learning center for Prescott College, the school that she, Matthew, and Jesse have all attended. This learning center seeks to bring together Prescott College distance students of the northeast and the many potential mentors in this area. She also continues to work on transcriptions from ongoing interviews.

Annie has been working on a farm that uses draft animals in its food production. She is lucky to be learning things that few modern farmers know about!!! We are lucky to receive her writings on the subject!

Cook has been studying with a woman who is proficient in traditional Italian faith healing, and with his study he is filling in gaps that were left in our own research. What a blessing that he has found this teacher.

We are holding many events through this year. I am especially excited about the November guild meeting this year which will focus on traditional Deitsch architecture and its application in Green building. I hope that you all enjoy this issue, and I hope we get to see your faces at some of our upcoming guild meetings!!!

Blessings, All of us at Three Sisters Center

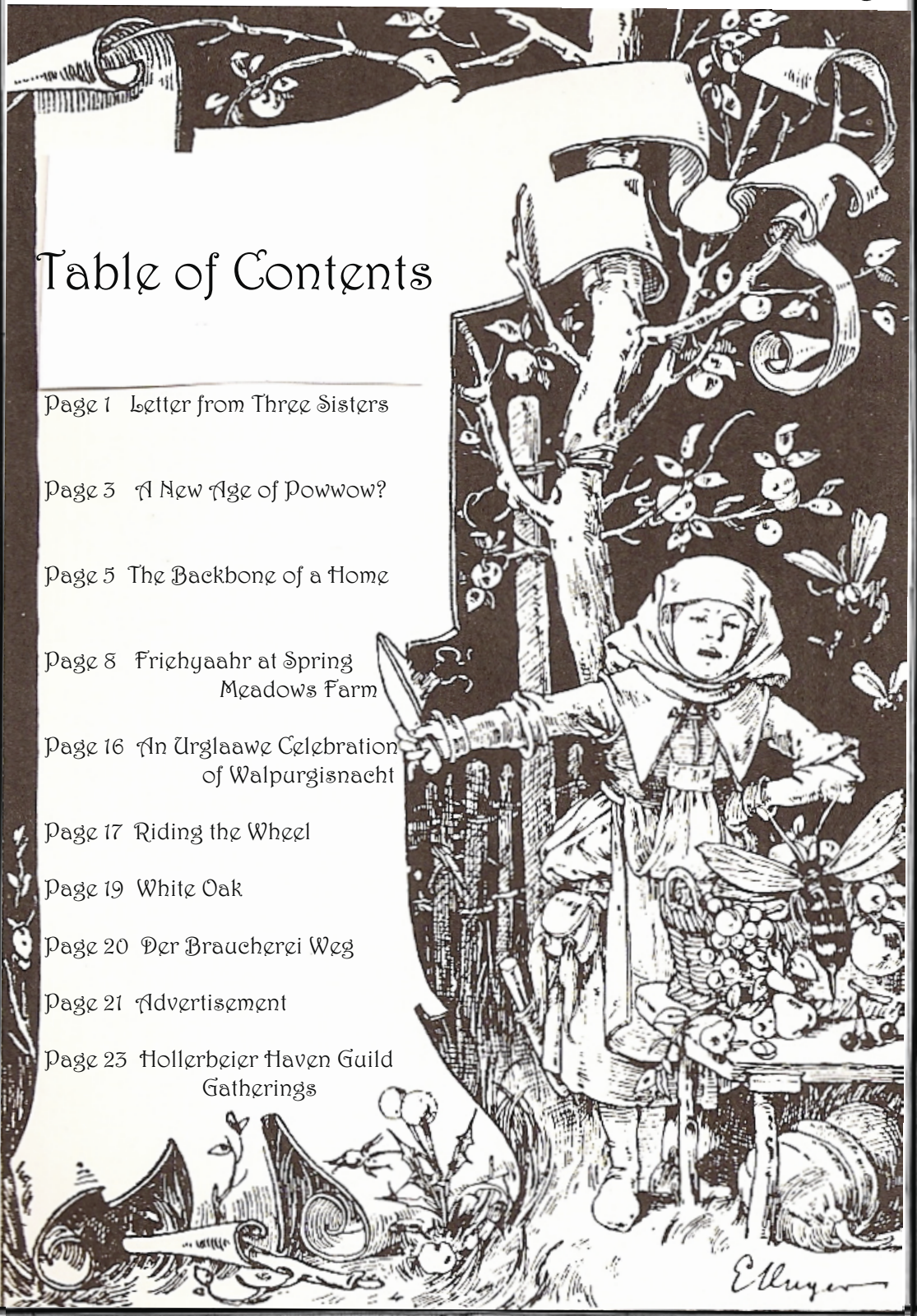


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A New Age of Powwow? Or a Time Honored Tradition? Misconception and Misnomers about the Three Sisters Project By Jesse Tobin



It has been several times now that Three Sisters has come up against a rather misguided accusation. It is no secret that Three Sisters Center acts according to the code of conduct given to us through the Oley Freindschaft. It is also no secret that this adherence to a code of oral tradition often puts us into conflict with various other groups, some Christian, some Heathen, some academic. It is important to say, however that in all of these corners of the community we also find friends, and those who are sympathetic to our cause, which is one not of preservation, but of the revival of a living tradition.

Among many in these circles the term "new age" is used to belittle or diminish our line of work. Several times in the past few years the work of Three Sisters has been labeled "new age," clearly in an attempt to belittle, demonize, or otherwise discredit the work we are doing. Most often these accusations are made by people who have never conversed with us about this work or else conversed very little, and in less than honest circumstances. Unfortunately, it is often also the case that those who would discredit our work are also moving in circles that very well might otherwise work in symbiosis with us toward a common goal. It is a shame to see so much in fighting when there could be great efforts of cooperation toward the common good. Our culture, our history, our language, and our religious sensibilities as a whole would be bettered by such cooperation, and in the case of language and culture, there is little time to spare on quarrels.

So I am writing this article to set the record straight, and to clarify our practices and methodology in gathering the information that we have, in the hopes that this might end some of these quarrels, hopefully making friends where there were once perceived enemies… Ultimately I am hoping that the in fighting and name-calling can come to an end in the interest of the greater picture.

From the onset Three Sisters has always gone about our research and the sharing of our research in a folkloric way. By this I mean that we have taken our information directly from the elders who practice Braucherei, and we continue to practice and to teach practices according to

this oral tradition without modernizations. We do not attempt to look at traditional wisdom from an objective perspective, but instead we seek to understand it within the context of Deitsch culture and history itself. We have done this for several reasons. One is that there is more than enough information available from an academic perspective on the topic of Deitsch folklore and folk culture. The second is that gathering information in a folkloric way allows us to gather and integrate information that is relevant to contemporary and historical Braucherei practice that might otherwise be deemed somehow invalid or inapplicable (in a study that was more scientifically or sociologically oriented). Another reason is that many elders we have spoken with want nothing to do with academia… *they don't want to be studied; they want to pass their knowledge on to those who will practice it!* The last is that we hope that this angle would make the information accessible and interesting to the largest part of the population.

Although we acknowledge that there is a place for the academic model in historical and cultural work, we did not choose that model for our own work, as we believed it to be too limiting for what we hoped to accomplish. Our goal has never been to quantify or study the Pennsylvania Germans in a sociological way. Instead we have always hoped to act as a bridge from an older generation to a new one, with a goal of cultural continuation.

It is our understanding that the cultural degradation Deitsch culture suffered during the 20th century broke a line of inheritance to at least one, and perhaps two generations. This break created a gap of knowledge that spanned nearly half of the last century and left middle aged and young people of the 21st century with nowhere to turn for the return of this inheritance to their own hearts and minds.

As we have mentioned more than a few times, we inherited quite a bit of our research from our main mentor, Dennis Boyer. Dennis began his research in a very informal way (one that was oriented toward storytelling) in the early 1980's. Dennis started his research at a time when most of us at Three Sisters were either wearing diapers or changing them!! Because of his early start, and because of his close connection with several Brauchers who were heir to the Oley Freindschaft tradition, he was able to collect information that very well may otherwise have been lost entirely. Also, because he started at this time, he was able to collect information from elders who were in their 70's, 80's, and 90's then. The fact of their age meant that they had been raised in a time when Deitsch ancestry, language, and culture did not carry the stigma that it did for successive generations. He collected from a group of elders who had spoken Deitsch in school, and lived in an insulated Deitsch culture, before the stigmas of two world wars, urbanization, and the York Hex trials had come to roost. They practiced Braucherei healing and traditional agriculture without shame or fear. They held a wealth of traditional spiritual insights which, while certainly not falling into the category of orthodox, were widely held among the folk. These women and men were usually not living at the fringes of their communities (as is often said in academic lore), but were often integral members: storekeepers, hard working farmers, millers, etc.

In the time before we met Dennis, he was able to conduct around 78 interviews with different Brauchers of various ages, locations, and religious backgrounds. Though the majority of his information came from elders he knew in the areas surrounding Huff's Church, Pikeville, Oley, Hill Church, and Siesholzville; his search went far and wide and he found Brauchers across the country. He found them in every kind of church too, including Anabaptist

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The Backbone of a Home

By Matthew Sicher

We began by walking all throughout the deciduous beauty that is our land. Steve and I knew what we were looking for in finished somer beams, and we had to first find a grand tree of adequate dimensions. Deciding on a fine Red Oak of about twenty three inches diameter, we began with prayers of acknowledgement. We were felling a tree that was older than the both of us (we counted about 78 rings), and so as it came crashing to the ground (on the Spring Equinox), we could do so with a clear and intentional conscience.

Steve Groff is my second cousin, and had done much work of this kind, so it has brought me great joy to have him contributing not only his know-how, but also his skillful hands to the building of our house in a tangible way. I referred to Steve's involvement in the building of our mutual uncle Richard's house in the previous issue, and I'm profoundly happy that this type of work is seen as valuable among many generations of us. In the shaping of our somer beams we used a short-handled Broad Axe of Uncle Richard's (my Great Great Uncle), as well as a long-handled Broad Axe that was Jesse's Great Great Grandfather's!

On the first day of cutting Steve said, "Daniel O'Hagen said, "A sharp tool is a pleasure to use, a dull tool is drudgery"'. Mr. O'Hagen was a friend and dear influence of my Gram Betsy's, Cousin Steve's, and Uncle Richard's, and his initials are carved onto the handle of the Broad Axe that was given to Richard. He was a living example of accomplished, fine craftsmanship, and simple living who touched the lives of many; as do these, my elders, referred to within these pages.

So with well sharpened tools we proceeded with the shaping of the strong backbone of our future home. For some of the initial and deep cuts we used a chainsaw to cut to the desired depth, then the long-handled broad axe, or an adze to remove the cut areas. We then made a series of powerful diagonal cuts with a double edged axe, and removed that





wood with more cuts from the other direction. We went through these steps on all four sides, measuring all along the way and snaping chalk lines to find accurate dimensions.

Each beam was then hoisted onto a pair of substantial saw horses that Steve had made for previous timbers he had broad-axed into being. We experimented with several ways to get those hefty beams up onto the horses, including the use of a bait and tackle pulley system rigged onto a helpful and large tripod we put together.

Once up at chest level on the horses, we proceeded with the fine finishing. Using a square to account for irregularities, we went over every surface of the beams, taking off graceful long peels of wood with the broad axes to achieve a more smooth finish.

We were able to get both beams from just that one fine Red Oak, and that is a source of satisfaction for both of us. We had to go with two separate beams, because we needed thirty feet total, and two are much easier to manage than one very long one. We will also use the point where the beams meet as an opportunity to show off a nice ship joint and some wood peg joinery work.

Our work on the Somer Beams reflects our understanding that we are not trying to just do something "the old way". In fact, on some areas of the beams, we intentionally left a slightly rougher finish than is often seen in older displays of craftsmanship. We discussed the fact that quality and beauty are not only culturally defined, but also defined by the times in which the crafts are being made. In years past, an extremely smooth and uniform finish was a rare and tricky achievement with only hand tools.

Nowadays, we are surrounded by an incredible abundance of uniform building components. So in order to highlight our beams, some rough areas will draw the eye, and create a focal point. In a way



this is the essence of my building vision, create a home that is, in context, both in this time and place, while clearly anchored to the bedrock stability of times past. With attentiveness, luck, passion, faith, and elbow grease, I hope to see this vision become a reality.

I spoke specifically of the great role Steve Groff played in forming the backbone of our house, but there were also other hearts, hands, and minds involved. I hereby acknowledge Chris, Dan, Heath, Frank, my father Jeff, Patrick, and Jeremy. Your contribution to to what promises to be a strong, stable, and beautiful house (metaphorically and physically) is very tangible. Our Elders in our Deitsch culture had a knack for turning any physical task into a "frolic". What a pleasure to be continuing that practice, and teaching that it may be work, but it need not feel like a job!









Photographs on this page by Jeffrey Sicher





Friehyaar at Spring Meadows Farm by Annie Hasz

To work with the oxen, you must hold a conversation with them. As soon as you approach to catch them and begin to affect them, the conversation has begun. If they walk away, follow them at their pace until they stop. If they are still or turn towards you, pause for 2 seconds and even back away, look to the side: be indifferent. Having you close pressures them. You must show them that by standing still they can relieve the pressure and that your presence is not threatening. When you are close enough, smoothly slip the halter over the horns and ears while holding a horn. The horn is an instrument of communication and also a great point of leverage for a human who holds it. You must follow their rhythm of conversation, or association time, and interact within this framework. The human rhythm of conversation, or even the draft horse rhythm, is different.

Burt and Marvin, two Holstein oxen, are drafted for the heavy work at Spring Meadows Farm in Mosherville, Pennsylvania. Beginning a plowing or hauling project means beginning in consciousness: catching perceptive and sensitive animals and communicating with them, instead of just firing up the tractor. And while working you can not leave that consciousness or drift in the conversation, so to speak. I came to apprentice at Spring Meadows farm because I wanted to learn the skills necessary to farm with draft animals. After three years on vegetable-only farms with tractors for tillage, I was also itching to learn the skills necessary to manage a farm where vegetable production was integrated with animals of many kinds and the farm was managed as an agro-ecosystem. At Spring Meadows, a herd of dairy cows, several steers, the oxen, a flock of chickens, and pigs are rotated on the land and used to fertilize and till the soil. The farmer, Andy Lyon, is working to create a financially and ecologically sound farm. He is slowly scaling up diverse farm enterprises, including maple sugaring and firewood sales. Eventually, pasture-raised milk products will be the central enterprise on the farm and its waste products (cow



manure, skim milk + whey, etc) will be used to fuel other smaller enterprises or holons. This year I am working with him to scale up vegetable production to sell at two farmers' markets, one restaurant, and an on-farm stand. Meanwhile, we are also milking one cow, raising three pigs and three steers for beef, and selling about 7 dozen eggs a week at the local health food store. Next year, he will begin making maple syrup, increase his laying flock of chickens and perhaps raise more beef animals. Following this he will begin to scale up firewood sales and then, dairying. All these changes will happen while ensuring that the farm balance is maintained and soil quality is valued above all. Here, "pasture is the engine behind everything, biologically." The surrounding forest is valued as a center of biodiversity. Trees are understood as natural mineral miners and their roots hold the land's water. And this forest is the most wild that I have yet seen in Pennsylvania, full of Wake Robin and Snow Trilliums, Dutchman's Britches, Toothworts, Bloodroot, and enormous patches of wild Leeks or Ramps below a canopy of Ash, Elm, White Birch, Aspen, Maple, and Oak, Hemlock and many Serviceberries. Pileated woodpeckers laugh from the trees, bears wander through and bobcats are commonly seen. Last night I saw a skunk, I've found porcupine quills and woken up to owls hooting and animals running through the leaves, screeching and screaming.

I've been here just about 2 months but already I feel tied to the rhythm of the season's work. We are up at 5 AM for chores. Usually, when bringing in the cows I hear the drumming of a grouse coming from the woods by the creek (imagine a loud, distance bass beat with an accelerating rhythm) and dawn has finally caught up with our alarm clock. As I bring in the cows, the sky is now gray and beginning to show streaks of color. First, we groom and milk Green Bean, feed her calf Fava and our young Ayrshire calf named Bub, who we will train as part of a new oxen team. We water and feed the cows a mineral supplement Andy mixes, feed and water the chickens, feed and water the pigs, turn the compost pile composed of the winter's chicken manure and bedding which we will use to fertilize the potatoes. The cows – Lima, Green Bean, May, November, Carmel, Sable, and Maybelle -- are then turned out to graze in a new pasture. We put the oxen into their breakfast pasture. We clean the barn, sweeping all left-over minerals and hay into a pile to be divided between tomorrow's chicken and pig feed. We scrape the manure

into the gutter, then haul it to the compost pile and sweep the barn thoroughly. Then we sprinkle wood ashes on the wet spots and mix the next day's feed. The chickens are given fresh pasture every day along with a mix of corn, fish meal and a pinch of ground oyster shell (for strong shells) fermented overnight in skim milk from Green Bean. The pigs are pastured and also fed corn mixed with liquid and solid food wastes: a hearty slop! In the near future, Andy's ideal is to continue pasturing the pigs and chickens but feed them forage and grain that he grows himself, including millet for the chickens and hubbard squash for the pigs. Eventually, the pigs will be raised in woodlots, eating nuts and foraging for roots. Since the farm mimics an ecosystem, Andy consults the animals' wild diets and behavior as the authority on their care in his farm system.

Starting this week, we will begin to bring the cows in during the hottest afternoon hours for water and milking and use the early morning hours to cultivate in the one-acre garden. When not using the oxen to plow and help us cultivate and harrow, we draft ourselves and use a mixture of tools including wheelhoes, rakes, and circle hoes. Wheelhoes are oldfashioned class of garden tools, including seeders, hoes, and furrowers, attached to wheels. They are generally more efficient and less destructive than rototillers.

These days in the garden the onions are striving to be knee-high and the potatoes are just up. The peas, fava beans, cabbage, parsnips, lettuce, spinach, beets, chard, collards, kale, carrots, and broccoli are starting to take off in tight, neat green rows. The acre is divided into 5 plots: one for spring vegetables, one for summer vegetables, one for fall vegetables (which the pigs are currently grazing and rooting), one completely fallow growing grass, and one fallow with a patch of garlic and a patch soon to be growing flowers for market bouquets. After a long rainy evening spreading manure on the summer vegetable plot Andy calculated that we are spreading 45 tons to the acre of compost. The typical rate to fertilize to grow a corn crop, a very heavy feeder (meaning it requires lots of nitrogen and other nutrients) is 20 tons to the acre.

Andy's philosophies are simple, but revolutionary in today's culture. He grew up on a farm watching his father raise cattle without ever using a veterinarian and "assuming an independent authority" over the garden and the chickens by the age of eight. Through completion of degrees in forestry and dairy

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A New Age of Powwow continued from page 4.....

congregations, and plenty who, though profoundly devout in their own religious sensibilities, were not churchgoers at all.

We found Dennis through a series of chance circumstances, but mostly because we found a copy of his book *Once Upon a Hex*. As we read through it, we realized that the author of this book would have the knowledge we sought! Over time we developed a trusting friendship, and he agreed to apprentice me. In my wildest dreams, I never thought that he would choose to turn over all the materials he had accumulated about Braucherei, but ultimately, that is just what he did.

What I did not know at the time is that our arrival in his life was answering a wish for him as well: Dennis had long hoped to promote the continuation of the practice and spirituality surrounding Braucherei, but had no time or energy to devote to the cause. The arrival of several young and interested individuals gave him the opportunity to act as a bridge, passing the invaluable heirlooms of the Freindschaft on from a generation long gone to one that thirsted for their own culture.

Our work since this time has been constant in many areas. The information Dennis passed on to us was written in his less-than-legible handwriting, and Lauren Sicher (a member of the Kutzeschteddel Raad) has spent over a year transcribing those notes into a typed and readable format. As each interview has opened before our eyes new concepts are revealed, usually in tantalizing hints and suggestions of the next area to be uncovered.

We have diligently continued Dennis's work; we have taken on his legacy and furthered it. There is a long-standing misconception in the academic world that Braucherei is dead. In other words, it is believed that there are no more old-time practitioners. I must say first, that this is a misconception that has been held since at least the 1960's. Academia has been predicting the downfall and death of Braucherei for half a century or more. There is only one major problem with their theory: it is quite simply and undeniably incorrect.

Not only are there several of us now who have been trained in Braucherei to fill out a new generation of Brauchers, but I know of at least five practitioners living in the Berks/Lehigh/Schuylkill area who are well over 60 years old and still practicing. These are all individuals who learned Braucherei very traditionally and continue to practice it this way as well. These are also all individuals from whom we have learned. It is my opinion that, just as there always have been at least a few, there will always continue to be a few young people interested in serving their communities as Brauchers. Those of us involved in Three Sisters are only a handful of the most recent to take on this responsibility. It is also no surprise that there is ridicule from many different sources toward our work, this has also always been, and I would be shocked to see an end to it in my lifetime.

All this being said, there is another difficulty I have with the academic approach to the beliefs and practices that make up Braucherei. It is a simple fact that it is easier to study something if it is static and existing in isolation. Unfortunately it is nearly impossible to find anything in the human realm that would fit either of these two classifications. No culture or folk practices on earth would fit into these categories, yet the attitude of many academics in their approach to Deitsch culture is one which assumes the culture to be dead, or if not dead, then surely dying.

In addition the attitude is one that assumes that the folk cultural ways of the Deitsch developed and existed in a vacuum. One of the reasons that our work at Three Sisters has been labeled "new age" by some is that we acknowledge and learn from the many different cultural influences that have

molded Braucherei, and Deitsch culture as a whole over the centuries of its development.

Deitsch culture is heir to such a wide variety of influences partially due to the central location of Germany in the continent of Europe. Germany existed as the center of the Holy Roman Empire for centuries, which made it a center for religious, intellectual, and cultural exchange. It also made it central to nearly every major conflict that cris-crossed Europe since the invasion of the Indo-Aryan people.

Culture evolves in a continuous movement, as a living being. It is a constant universal theme of Humanity that we never stop learning from each other. Any time two groups of people inhabit the same or neighboring territories, you can bet there will be major cultural exchange. In this continuous evolution of culture it is easy to see how new elements are always added to ancient tradition to create a familiar yet exciting living tradition. The various cultural exchanges that affected Germanic culture were also essential to the creation of the Braucherei tradition that continues to live and thrive in the hills of Pennsylvania.

It is easy to see the indigenous heathen Germanic elements that are still present in the tradition and in the culture. They are everywhere and we have discussed them thoroughly in past issues of this newsletter: seasonal traditions that surround Christmas, Easter, Halloween, the planting, the harvest, etc. Spirits are specifically named in oral and written tradition that have been sacred to the Germanic people since time immemorial. Foods, customs, costume, lore, all these elements of our culture reflect our ancient Germanic heritage. There is so much more, however, that is reflected in our modern Deitsch culture. Upon examination of the face of Deitsch culture today it is easy to see the many influences: Germanic, Jewish, Catholic, Gnostic, Pietist, Classical Greek, French, Scandinavian, Scientific, Native American, Appalachian, Caribbean, etc. In exchange, Deitsch culture has also influenced and embellished other uniquely North American cultures. John George Hohman's *Lang Vorborgene Freund* spread down the Appalachians, into the Ozarks, and even further south into Louisiana and the Caribbean Islands. The charms in his book (and their Germanic influence) are now whispered, in English by the lips of so many folk healers: from granny doctors in Virginia and Tennessee, to Hoodoo and Rootwork practitioners in Louisiana Bayous.

In the herbal lore of the Deitsch it is easy to see the remnants of the Humoral medicine of the Greeks mixing with the individualist tenants of Samuel Thompson, the Blood diagnostics of the Southern Appalachians, and the more, well, *eclectic* ideas of the Eclectic physicians of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries.

There are two specific areas upon which accusations of our supposed "new age" nature have focused. The first is the strong and obvious influence of classical Greek philosophy and cultural perceptions in our classes and workshops. I can surely understand that, to one who knows little or nothing about our project or the evolution of German culture, it would be easy to compare our medicine wheel, yearly calendar, and references to astrology to many self-titled "new age" movements. There are several differences, however, both superficial and deep.

First, I would like to address the fact that the Greek medical and philosophical influence on Germanic culture is nothing new. Humoral medicine, astrology, and other less well-known Greek arts such as knuckle bone divination, alchemy, and Gnosticism were first introduced to the Germanic tribes in the early period of Christian conquest. Hildegard von Bingen (1098-1179) used Humoral theory (as well as other Aristotelian and Platonic theories) heavily in her various works on medicine, religion, and nature. Alburtis Magnus, a well-known Dominican monk of the middle ages also discussed the natural world

primarily in the context of the Greek Humoral system. In fact, it was against the well-established practice of medicine according to the Galenic interpretation that the famous "people's doctor" Paracelsus pitted himself in the 15th century.

In addition to the Greek influence over the medical system of the Deitsch, it is impossible not to acknowledge the extreme importance of Greek Astrology to the Deitsch farmers of Pennsylvania. Traditional farmers continued the use of the almanac for its astrological, moon based agricultural guides well into the middle of the 20th century. So it cannot be said that the presence of Greek theories and influence in our understanding of Braucherei makes our work "new age".

The strongest deluge of Greek, Gnostic, and even Jewish influence came in the late 15th century with the fall of Constantinople to the Turkish Empire. With this defeat, the Greek Christian scholars fled west, bringing with them their scrolls and books filled with classical, Gnostic, Kabalic, and early Christian philosophy. Incidentally it was very shortly thereafter that the printing press was invented and put to use in Germany. Like a match to tinder, the populace of central Europe (many of them radical pietists already), dissatisfied with the corruption and dogma of the Catholic church, and craving a deeper wisdom, dove headlong into the movements that eventually brought about the renaissance, the reformation, the legacy of German intellectualism, and ultimately the great emigration to other lands (of which Pennsylvania was one).

Naturally, the Greek, Kabalic, Medieval Catholic, and even pre-Christian that had been integrated over centuries of cultural evolution did not leave our ancestors simply because they changed location. If anything, I would say that the initial immigrants to Pennsylvania were among those with the most radical viewpoints: from Anabaptists to the radical piety of the Wissahickon mystics and the Ephrata cloister, and from the communal Moravians to the starkly individualist, and near libertarian mountain pioneers; few that undertook the treacherous crossing of the Atlantic were of a middle of the road or meek perspective.

These were people in search of a yet uncharted future, who refused to allow the whims of church and state to dictate their lives. They adhered to their own moral and cultural compass, and if anything, the freedom of mind they found in Pennsylvania only served to allow many of the more unorthodox ideas to flourish. That the influence of the ancients was still felt in the Deitsch countryside is clear when we look at such books as *Sauer's Herbal Cures, The 6th and 7th Books of Moses* (based loosely on an older Jewish book *The Lesser Key of Solomon*), various almanacs, and even *The Long Lost Friend* (the famed powwow handbook). All of these books were mainstays of the PA German farming communities of the 18th, 19th, and 20th centuries.

With the migration into an area already populated by the native people to southeastern Pennsylvania, the diversity of influences was compounded further with the influence of several groups of Native Americans, but especially the Lenni Len'ape, the Susquahannocks, and the Seneca. There is clear evidence of cohabitation of certain regions, such as the Oley Valley, for extended periods of time. There are several aspects of Braucherei that have clearly been influenced by our time in America (such as our medicine and moon wheels, and our sweat lodges), but it is hard to know to what extant these things came out of a native influence, and to what extant they may have already existed.

Our medicine wheel, moon calendar, feast days, and entire healing tradition are heir to, and a result of these many influences. The interpretation of Braucherei that is taught by the Three Sisters project is one that

has been compiled from many different practitioners. It is important to note, however, that in reference to the more controversial aspects such as the moon and medicine wheels, the feast days, and the shamanic elements of the healing practice; these seemingly controversial or potentially "new age" aspects of Braucherei were spoken of by several practitioners who knew these calendars and healing ways intimately, and who had inherited these practices from their elders.

Surely most full-time Brauchers were a bit unorthodox in their beliefs, but because of this reference of many practitioners to the same theories, worldviews, and concepts, it cannot be said that our work is based on the oddball beliefs of one off-the-wall Braucher. It may be hard for my more academically oriented fellows to swallow, but these beliefs and practices come from the mouths of traditional elders who are, most of them, now passed on to their reward. Our use of the medicine wheel, astrology, and seasonal celebration reflects only what we have learned through folkloric transmission of traditional practice along with our own research into the origins and evolution of those practices. Many academics would scoff at this remark simply because they deem folkloric knowledge barely above worthless, and that is their right. My fellows and I at Three Sisters, however, deem it more valuable than gold, and make no apologies for this stance.

One last issue that has (and will again, no doubt) reared its ugly head, is one of religion. It is no secret or surprise to the readers of this journal that the Braucherei practitioners of the Three Sisters Center hold to an assortment of various spiritual beliefs and doctrines. Some within our fold are of a traditional Deitsch faith: Lutheran, UCC, Brethren, Schwenkfelders, etc. Others associate themselves with non-traditional, but Christian faiths such as Catholicism or Gnosticism. A few of us hold to more ancient beliefs, as in the newly forming Urglaawe, which bases its tenets on the pre-Christian beliefs and practices that still remain alive in Deitsch culture. Yet others opt to combine these many influences, creating a patchwork quilt of belief that is a very eclectic, but no less valid (and perhaps more fitting to a Braucher, anyway) system of belief and spirituality.

Few, if any of the old practitioners specified that a Braucher should be of a certain faith. Nearly all of them said there was a need for strong faith, but many of them said flat out that there was no need even to be Christian! That said, it is also important to say that Pennsylvania (due to its establishment on the core principle of absolute freedom of religion) was a haven to those of peculiar and unorthodox beliefs from the start (as mentioned earlier). Within our Freindschaft of Braucherei there is a well-established and thoroughly trodden path of devout, but non-church going and unaffiliated individuals. This fact, however, has made them no less effective or appreciated as Brauchers and folk healers. In fact, in the early settlement of Pennsylvania, many of these practitioners acted as lay ministers in the absence of other ordained members of the clergy, and acted as the only spiritual guidance available to the pioneers of the frontier areas.

As our culture has evolved in the 20th century, more and more people who consider themselves Deitsch in every other respect, have moved away from the traditional Reformed, Lutheran, and Anabaptist congregations of our past. They have flocked in various directions, but in general the younger generations of Deitsch people are more willing to be open about their spiritual explorations, beliefs, and discoveries.

To this end I would request the same tolerance and observation of religious freedom that has been granted in this state since before King George was overthrown. Our various faiths do nothing in truth but enrich our spiritual health as individuals, and certainly do not impede our abilities to practice as traditional Brauchers of the Oley



Deitsch culture is unique in many ways. The fact of its language and rural nature did keep it somewhat insulated from surrounding cultures. It is my opinion, however, that this insulation simply served to slow the transmission of information, not to halt it altogether. Deitsch people, as all people, have examined, explored, and eventually put to use the beliefs and practices of their neighbors throughout their history. This seems to me a natural enough evolution of culture, and one that is easy to observe among any group of people. Thus it is surprising to me that so many would choose to write off this assertion and its application in the Three Sisters project before they have examined the foundations of our work.

It is a wonder and a joy to see these many influences that have shaped our Braucherei tradition. The study of this many fold path has become the all-encompassing purpose of the Three Sisters Center. It has been exciting work thus far, and I expect it will continue to be in the years to come. This newsletter and our many workshops and courses strive to create a situation in which this material can be shared with the public in an open venue. I invite discussion on this topic, in the interest of openness, clarity, understanding, and ultimately mutual benefit with all those working toward similar goals. Let's work together to keep our culture alive and healthy! + + +

Freiyaahr continued from Page 8....

science and subsequent work experience on dairies and vegetable farms throughout Pennsylvania, he formed a "deep understanding of why the traditional system [he] grew up with worked so well".

He is living the life of his childhood, but now he's in the management role. He's living a life he loves and so this farm is first about joy and health through practices all intended to build soil fertility and create satisfaction in working. I am lucky enough to learn these practices and share them as I begin to plan my own farm. Some basics: Food must be Good for You, nutrient-dense and flavorful so it nourishes you on many levels. Preparing, eating and sharing food must be a joy. If it's not, why grow it? Your health must be sound, and care for yourself a priority. If its not, why work so hard? Work must be interesting, creative, energizing, and yes, it will be exhausting sometimes, but on the whole enjoyable. If it's not, why farm? + + +

An Urglaawe Celebration of Walpurgisnacht

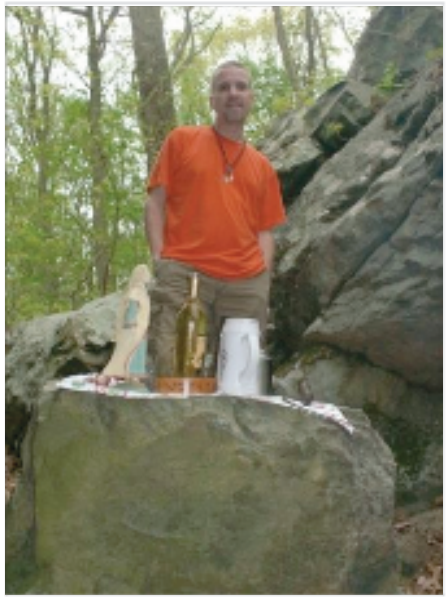
By Rob Lusch

Walpurgisnacht (April 30) is an old German holiday with Heathen roots. The original name of the day was probably lost through time, though Walpurga (or Walburga) became associated with the goddesses Holle and Berchta, who may be regional perceptions of the same goddess.

In Pennsylvania German traditions, Holle remained known to practitioners of Braucherei throughout the centuries. April 30 is seen as the night that marks Her return from the Wild Hunt and the end of the dark half of the year. Her return to the soil hails they way for outdoor planting. We celebrate the fertility of the land and the processing and settling of souls during the Wild Hunt. We focus on the cycles of life: birth, death, rebirth; sowing, reaping, replanting. An appropriate rune for meditation is Jera.

The site at which we held our ceremony is also associated with the goddess Freya due to its magical lore, so we hailed Freya and were visited by a peregrine falcon, a symbol of Freya, during our ceremony. An appropriate rune for meditation with Freya is Fehu.

The statuaries of Holle and Freya are presented in a cart around my home. In the future, this practice will expand to the town or to the site of the ceremony. The celebration itself is a typical Urglaawe ceremony consisting of a Sege (blessing) and a Sammel (sumble). Bright colors, flowers, words hailing the goddesses and the gods. We are to open our windows and doors and to post a sign over the entrances reading, "WALPURGIS" to invite the spirit of Holle into our homes.



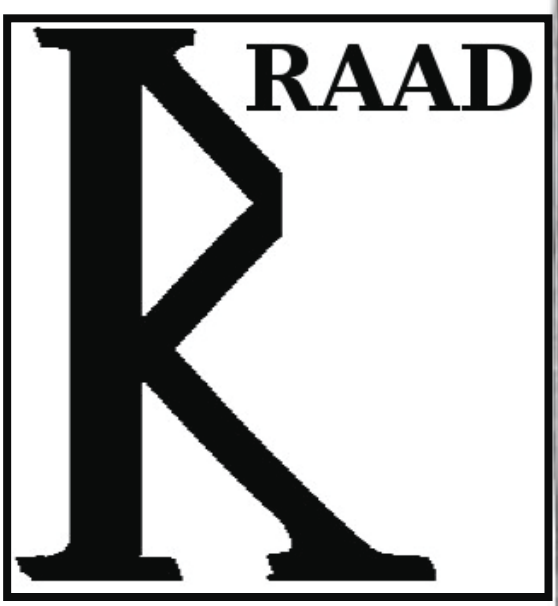


The next day, May Day, is an appropriate time to recognize the power of male creative energies and the sacrifices that males make in order to ensure that the cycle of life continues. Although Holle has re-energized the soil, outdoor planting of sensitive plants should not begin until after May 15. Pennsylvania German lore states that there are three remaining Reifries (Frost Giants) who will visit the land on May 13, 14, and 15.

Walpurgisnacht is one of the most important holidays in Urglaawe. The entry into the light half of the year is a time for us to move our focus from internal issues to external issues. Our New Year's Resolutions should be well in process already. Between now and Midsummer is the time to celebrate the joys of life: family, community, faith, warmth, fertility. +++

Riding the Wheel
Raad – The Fifth Rune
by Patrick J. Donmoyer

+ + +



"Riding in the hall is very pleasant,
It is more strenuous,
Sitting on a strong horse covering
The mile paths."
- Anglo-Saxon Rune Poem, Thomas Howard Translation

The fifth rune in the Germanic Futhark is named Raad, a word meaning both wheel or council. As many of the runes' shapes reflect their meaning, such as the case of Thorn resembling Thor's hammer, Raad is a pictogram of Thor's solar chariot, which was believed by the ancient Norse and Germanic peoples to carry the sun across the sky. This daily journey of the sun is considered a metaphor for cosmic regularity and order, giving rise to a sacred concept of time. The rune Raad is therefore associated with the cyclical nature of the universe, and the wheel of the year. Images of the wheel in cave paintings appear as early as 20,000 years before the common era. Carl Jung, in *The Spirit of Man in Art and Literature,* explains that the image of the multi-spoked wheel as a symbol appears thousands of years before the invention of the wheel as a mechanism. It was Jung's belief that the earliest wheel symbols could not be referring to an actual device or physical object, and they were therefore referential to an internal state of being. The wheel as a physical, artistic representation of an internal concept was representative of the relationship of early humans and their observation of the heavens and celestial cycles.

The concept of the wheel is deeply embedded in the beliefs and traditions of the Germanic people, ranging in implications from celestial order to agricultural cycles; from equestrian warfare to travel; from shamanic initiation to transnavigation of the nine worlds. Historically the wheel is responsible for enabling the military conquests of the Germanic people, allowing them to expand across continental Europe by means of the chariot. By the time the tribes transitioned from a lifestyle of nomadic herding to stationary agriculture, the wheel was synonymous with agricultural productivity. The wheel allowed for the Germanic peoples to thrive, making the device a divine blessing from the gods. Images and icons of the wheel abound in ancient art, and continue to persist in the present day in traditional geometric designs. The wheel in Germanic and Norse iconography is frequently depicted as a circle surrounding an intersection of eight spokes. The eight spokes, with a central hub, is an

emblem of the nine words of the Germanic universe, which surround the world-tree, Yggdrasil. Often, the father-god Wodan's mystical eight-legged horse Slepnir is depicted as a wheel with eight spokes and a central hub, where Wodan would ride. This design is emblematic of Wodan's ability to transnavigate the worlds, as he could be in one world, and Slepnir would simultaneously have a hoof in every other world. As Wodan presided over shamanic practice, this reinforces the role of the shaman as a universal traveler.

The concept of the wheel is equally applicable to human interactions. As Raad can literally mean council, the visual depiction of a circle with multiple spokes and a central hub which revolves around an axis can be likened to a group of individuals devoted to a common purpose. In Pennsylvanisch Deitsch culture, the word Raad is still used in the present day in Powwow lore to refer to a group of shamanic practitioners. This reinforces the necessity of a community of focussed participants in order to foster spiritual growth, encourage right conduct, and perpetuate traditional teachings.

The significance of Raad in divination is related to all of these specific meanings, retaining the overarching metaphor of cyclical progression and divine continuity. It can indicate the need for exploration of other modes of being, relating to Wodan's transcendent traveling upon the world tree. Raad connects the nine worlds to a common source, Yggdrasil, which is the central axis and source of universal stability. Raad can indicate that a querent must seek the balance which comes from an understanding of the cosmological and divine cycles, and an integration of that knowledge into an active form of decision-making. The collective aspect of Raad as a council also indicates that universal harmony and connection is not possible without the reinforcement of a community.

If Raad is inverted, it can indicate that one is not working in harmony with the cyclical nature of existence. As cycles beget a certain level of continuity and repetition, if one is not sufficiently oriented to the ramifications and consequences of their actions, Raad could portend that one's life patterns are cyclical in a self-destructive, or communally destructive manner. In this case, the rune calls for re-adjustment based upon self awareness. As always, the meaning of the rune in a divinatory casting or reading is dependent upon other surrounding runes. If, for instance, Raad is cast in conjunction with an inverted Thorn, it could indicate that the querent's awareness of the cyclical nature of existence will lend enough strength to overcome the possibility of danger. However, an inverted Raad in conjunction with an upright Ansur could show that a querent must listen to the wisdom of elders to gain a greater understanding of the patterns of existence.

Previous articles have offered the simplest form of divinatory casting, involving a single rune method. Another simple method is the three-rune method, where three runes are selected from the set of twenty-four, and dropped from the hand at random. The first rune dropped is representative of the past, the second the present, and the third the future. If the querent is seeking insight into a certain present circumstance, the rune representing the past can offer an explanation for how the situation came to be. The second rune can reveal an aspect of the present scenario, and the third, the consideration of a possible outcome. This method, being very straight-forward and simple, can be used with positive results by both beginners and seasoned querents. + + +

White Oak

Quercus alba

'Tanner's Tree' 'der Weisseeche'

Research Compiled by Susan Hess

William Penn met with the Delaware Indians under the protective branches of a great white oak (called the Treaty Oak) to negotiate the purchase of Penn's Woods (Pennsylvania). This tree still survives in southern Chester County near Kennet Square. It is the largest White Oak in recorded Pennsylvania history measuring 21 feet in circumference. Years ago the leaves, acorns and galls of these ancient trees were collected by healing practitioners who traveled long and far to gather this 'medicine' that was considered to have exceptional healing abilities.

Taste: bitter and drying

Active properties: astringent, anti-inflammatory, antiseptic, styptic = stops bleeding, acorns are slightly tonic and nutritive

Part Used: the inner bark, leaves and acorns

Primary Uses: The high tannin content of the bark is extremely astringent in nature. The bark can be decocted and employed to halt chronic diarrhea and dysentery. Generally one ounce of bark was added to one quart of water and simmer down to one pint of liquid and strained for use.

Topical Applications: The bark was made into a strong decoction, then applied as a compress for inflamed hemorrhoids, weeping eczema, inflammatory eye conditions, ringworm, bedsores and open ulcers on the legs. Used also a wash for bleeding gums and toothaches and a gargle for irritations of the mouth and throat. A wash of oak bark combined with witch hazel bark is an excellent compress for varicose veins and broken capillaries.



Historical Information& Notes

The mighty oak has been revered by many cultures throughout millennia as a symbol of strength, stamina, longevity, abundance and protection. The acorns were a symbol of fertility which were carried as a talisman for initiating any creative endeavor including human reproduction. The Indo-European cultures associated the Oak tree with their gods of the sky, particularly those of thunder and lightning (Thor/Donar) The White Oak, a noble American tree, is well known for its many uses including ship and home building, barrel making, heating the home and for tanning animal hides.

Resource Materials:

The Earthwise Herbal-Complete Guide to New World Plants. Matthew Wood 2009
The Book of Herbal Wisdom. Matthew Wood 1997
Sauer's Herbal Cures. William Woys Weaver 2001
Folk Medicine Plants used in the PA Dutch Country. Paul Wieand 1971
Compendium of Symbolic and Ritual Plants in Europe- DeCleene/LeJeune 2003
Plant Names and Plant Lore of the PA Germans. Lick & Brendle 1923

Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts Presents:

Der Braucherei Weg +++ The Braucherei Path

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"The Braucherei Path" will provide an overview of the history and evolution of the unique spiritual and healing traditions of the Pennsylvania Germans. Students will explore the historical roots of Braucherei (also known as "powwow") from pre-Christian times to the present. In particular they will focus on the evolution of the mystical cosmology through the many waves of cultural influence in both Europe and America. Students will be given a basic understanding of traditional theories and practices of Braucherei tradition. Active discussion of the ongoing re-systemization of this living but fragmented tradition will be encouraged and facilitated throughout the course. This is a course for the interested historian and cultural revivalist as well as the serious student of the healing arts. Future apprentices in the Braucherei healing tradition will be selected from graduates of this course.

The course curriculum includes, but is not limited to:

+++ Pre-Christian history and contributions to the tradition from the Roman, Celtic, and Germanic peoples

+++ Jewish and early Christian influence on the tradition

+++ German Mysticism of the middle ages

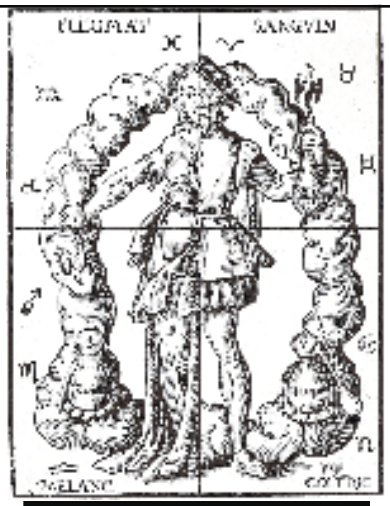
+++ Hermetic influence upon the tradition

+++ History and mystical traditions of the reformation

+++ Early Pennsylvania Braucherei

+++ Native American influence Twentieth century Braucherei

+++ Differentiation between Braucherei and Hexerei



+++The decline of Braucherei

+++ Cultural revival

+++ Survey of the current day tradition

+++ Cosmology and world view of modern day Brauchers

+++ Physical prayers

+++ Visual prayers

+++ Prayers in the world of spirit

+++ Folk herbal tradition

+++ Folk agricultural tradition

+++ New trends in Braucherei and the ongoing resystemization of the tradition

For more information, contact Jesse Tobin at:

484-336-4611

or by email at:

Thr3sisters@aol.com

www.ThreeSistersCenter.com

Der Braucherei Weg is now available to distance students, Contact Jesse for more information!



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Contact Rob Lusch:

by telephone at 215-499-1323

or

by email at schreiwer@urglaawe.org

Hollerbeier Haven Guild Gatherings June to October 2009

June 27th, 2009 Blanzeschwetze- "Speaking with Plants"

Held at Farm at Coventry in Pottstown, PA In June Jesse Tobin and Susan Hess will join together to discuss the Braucherei practice of "Blanzeschwetze" (speaking with plants). They will also discuss the ritual use of herbs in Braucherei. There are several medicinal herbs that are particularly important to the PA German healing tradition. Susan and Jesse will explain in depth about some of these plants: their character, cultural significance, and use in medicine and healing ceremony.

July 25th 2009: Ceremonies in Life Transition

The Braucherei tradition includes ceremonies for nearly every conceivable life transition. At this gathering we will focus on the various transitional ceremonies (ie: Birth, Coming of Age, Death, etc), as well as simple ceremonies of the day to day. We will discuss the traditional use of these ceremonies, and the variations we have found among the Braucherei community. We will explore the wholeness and harmony that the presence of ceremony can bring to our lives and how we can incorporate these traditional ways into our modern world.

August 29th: Urglaawe- "the Original Faith

August's gathering will focus on "Urglaawe" or "Original Faith". Urglaawe is a heathen faith based upon Continental Germanic and Pennsylvania German tradition. Rob Lusch will be sharing his knowledge of Urglaawe with us during this gathering. He has been working tirelessly to establish Urglaawe as a recognized faith, and to revive and educate others about its evolution, beliefs, and practices of Urglaawe. We will be discussing the long-standing beliefs and traditions that are central to Urglaawe and their relevance in modern life.

September 26th: Wheel of the Year, Part 2

During our August gathering we will discuss the dark half of the year, from Alleliebeziel (Halloween) to Walpurgisnacht (May Eve). The information we will be sharing comes predominantly out of the Oley Braucherei Freindschaft (the Oley lineage of Braucherei). We will focus on the major and minor feasts acknowledged in the Braucherei tradition during this part of the year. In addition to this we will explore the significance of each of the six moons, of this half of the year. We will discuss the significance of each moon from the perspective of the Greek Zodiac and the Oley-Pikeville moon Calendar.

October 31st: Psychic Self Defense

Everyday we swim through a sea of energy, emotion, and thought. Waves of energy and emotion connect us all to each other often in healthy and beneficial ways, but not always. Despite this, most people of today's world do not consider or concern themselves with thoughts of psychic psychic self-defense. October's gathering will focus on methods of spiritual self-defense from the Braucherei tradition. We will cover a variety of practices from charms and sympathies to the breaking of hexes, as well as the use of seasonal work in psychic self-defense.

All Guild Gatherings with the exception of June's will be held from 10 am to 3 pm at Indigo Natural Healing Center near Kutztown, PA.

The cost for attendance is $35 for Hollerbeier Haven Subscribers, and $45 for non-subscribers. For more information, contact Jesse Tobin: 484-336-4611

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